

The problem lies in a condition called repetitive stress injury (RSI), where you can injure your body by doing the same thing in the same posture day in and day out. RSI can attack anyone, from the manual worker to the gamer.

In what follows, we stick to the dangers posed to us by long hours spent on the computer. To find out how to protect your body while doing absolutely any type of job, refer to the box: *The Ergonomic Web* on page 78.

The Aches

People have been known to suffer from backaches, neck pain, eye strain, finger and forearm pain after exceptionally long computer use. Of these, eye strain and finger and forearm pain are direct effects of using a computer (of course, it's the monitor, keyboard and mouse that are to blame). Backaches and neck pains are a result of the way we sit. Let's take a look at these side-effects one by one and figure out the best practice in each case.

The Back And Neck

Those of you who have suffered severe back pain or slipped discs will surely vouch for the importance of looking after your spine. This is not just another ache, and not just another part of your body: injuries to the spine can be debilitating, and even life-threatening in extreme cases. The body just cannot function without the support of the spine, so you need to make sure you take every little backache and muscle spasm in the spine region very seriously.

At work, the spine is put to risk by the type of chair you use, and how you use it. A chair that hasn't been designed with ergonomics in mind can cause back pain. But even if you have a good chair designed to take weight off your back, are you sitting the correct way? We'll soon talk about chairs with good ergonomic design.

The Eyes

Eye strain is almost always associated with the type of monitor you use, the distance and angle at which it is placed, the screen resolution you work at, and also whether you remember to blink and take focus away from the monitor from time to time. More on this later when we look at monitors.

The Fingers And Arms

Very often, discomfort in these areas is not caused by using the keyboard and mouse the wrong way, but simply by not positioning them properly. A chair can also help the arms by providing good padded arm rests, as can placing the mouse at the correct location and height.

The most common complaint is the Carpal Tunnel Syndrome (CTS), a disorder that affects a nerve in the wrists, causing tingling, pain and weakness in parts of the hand. CTS is perhaps the most well-known RSI, and is beginning to affect more people worldwide—all because of the bad placement of a mouse or keyboard!

Office Furniture

Here we show you how you can decide whether the furniture you're using is ergonomically right or wrong. Remember, just having the right furni-

ture does not mean you're safe—you also need to know how to use it.

Chairs

The major cause of back and neck aches, a bad chair can really mess up your spine, especially if you are sitting in it eight hours a day.

As a rule of thumb, a good chair is one in which you feel comfortable. This may sound vague, but our point is that comfort is a very subjective matter—one person's comfort could be another's pain. So to begin with, just make sure your chair feels comfortable.

Most chairs today have adjustable parts, so if your chair just doesn't seem right, try adjusting the height. The proper height is achieved when you can sit in the chair and comfortably rest the soles of your feet on the ground. A low height would be if you find that the backs of your thighs are raised above the chair seat, and too high would be when you cannot comfortably place your feet flat on the ground.

The next thing to look for is an adjustable seat. Since our heights differ, a shorter person would need less seat space, and may need to move the seat backwards towards the backrest. On the other hand, a tall person would need to move the seat forwards.

An adjustable backrest is also important—not just in terms of height, but also in terms of the angle at which it meets your back. The more adjustable the backrest, the more the chances of you feeling comfortable in various positions.

Leaning back on an adjustable backrest helps to take weight off your lower spine, and that's very relaxing. Contrary to popular belief, a straight-back chair is not exactly ergonomic—not unless you're strapped to it. It's better to have a chair with an adjustable backrest that allows you to bend your back a little from time to time, in order to shift the weight.

Apart from the design of the chair, you need to remember to keep shifting your weight about at regular intervals. This helps improve the blood



Well-designed chairs can make life at work much easier, and can also bring relief to your aching back